end of April Kennedy had approved in principle a contingency plan that would take 60,000 US troops eight days to implement.[79]

According to Ted Sorensen, 'The lessons of the Bay of Pigs altered Kennedy's entire approach – to executive management and foreign policy in general and to conflicts in the developing nations in particular.'[80] What Sorensen does not convey is Kennedy's instinct for revenge. There is little doubt that the President (and even more so, his brother) saw getting rid of Castro in personal terms. However, the impulse to invade Cuba passed, as the 'tempers of the moment' (to use a phrase with which Adlai Stevenson would counsel caution in October 1962) faded. Contingency planning remained contingency planning, though the exercise did little to temper the desire of the Joint Chiefs to use US military forces to settle the problem of communism in 'America's backyard'.

What the President did not do after the Bay of Pigs was to conduct any reappraisal of CIA covert action. As the ever-eloquent Sorensen put it, Kennedy 'did not doubt either the necessity or legitimacy of "dirty tricks" when confronted with a covert conspiratorial adversary in an age of hidden perils.'[81] Neither Maxwell Taylor's Cuba Study Group, nor any senior figure in the national security apparatus, challenged the premise that the United States should secretly intervene in the affairs of other nations. Certainly, none of Kennedy's trusted senior advisers advocated abandoning the secret war against Fidel Castro.

Instead, the Kennedy administration embarked on a massive effort to destabilise and overthrow the Cuban government. The curiously titled Operation Mongoose was launched in November 1961 (the name may have come from Rudyard Kipling's story of a mongoose who devours a family of baby snakes to prevent them growing up and eating him). The operation was designed to 'help the people of Cuba overthrow the Communist regime from within Cuba and institute a new government with which the United States can live in peace'.[82] A provisional timetable drawn up in February 1962 envisaged open revolt and the overthrow of Castro by early October, followed later that month by the establishment of a new government.

The planning of Operation Mongoose involved senior figures within the administration including John McCone, McGeorge Bundy, Robert